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UNITED STATES BANKRUPTCY COURT
SOUTHERN DISTRICT OF NEW YORK

In re: CELSIUS NETWORK LLC, *et al.*,[1] Debtors. CELSIUS NETWORK LIMITED and CELSIUS NETWORK LLC (POST-EFFECTIVE DATE DEBTORS) Plaintiffs. against TETHER LIMITED; TETHER HOLDINGS LIMITED; TETHER INTERNATIONAL LIMITED; and TETHER OPERATIONS LIMITED, Defendants.	Chapter 11 Case No. 22-10964 (MG) (Jointly Administered) Adv. Pro. No. 24-04018 (MG) Case No. 22-10964 (MG) (Jointly Administered) Adversary Proceeding No. _____

COMPLAINT

[1] The reorganized Debtors in these chapter 11 cases, along with the last four digits of each Debtor's federal tax identification number, are: Celsius Network LLC (2148); Celsius KeyFi LLC (4414); Celsius Lending LLC (8417); Celsius Mining LLC (1387); Celsius Network Inc (1219); Celsius Network Limited (8554); Celsius Networks Lending LLC (3390); Celsius US Holding LLC (7956); GK8 Ltd (1209); GK8 UK Limited (0893); and GK8 USA LLC (9450). The location of Debtor Celsius Network LLC's principal place of business and the Debtors' service address in these chapter 11 cases is 50 Harrison Street, Suite 209F, Hoboken, New Jersey 07030.

Plaintiffs Celsius Network Limited and Celsius Network LLC (the Post-Effective Date

COMPLAINT

Debtors) ("Post-Effective Date Debtors" or "Celsius" or "Plaintiffs" or "Debtors") bring this

Plaintiffs Celsius Network Limited and Celsius Network LLC (the Post-Effective Date Complaint against Tether Limited, Tether Holdings Limited, Tether International Limited, and Tether Debtors) ("Post-Effective Date Debtors" or "Celsius" or "Plaintiffs" or "Debtors") bring this Operations Limited ("Tether" or "Defendants"), and allege the following based on reasonable due Complaint against Tether Limited, Tether Holdings Limited, Tether International Limited, and diligence of the Debtors' books and records, on personal knowledge as to themselves and their own Tether Operations Limited ("Tether" or "Defendants"), and allege the following based on acts, and upon information and belief as to all other matters:

reasonable due diligence of the Debtors' books and records, on personal knowledge as to

NATURE OF THE CASE

themselves and their own acts, and upon information and belief as to all other matters:

1. Plaintiffs bring this case to avoid and recover preferential and fraudulent transfers of

NATURE OF THE CASE

39,542.42 Bitcoin[2] from Celsius to Tether, first intended to secure, and subsequently applied on

1. Plaintiffs bring this case to avoid and recover preferential and fraudulent transfers of 39,542.42 Bitcoin from Celsius to Tether, first intended to secure, and subsequently applied on account of, antecedent debt Celsius owed to Tether. These transfers undoubtedly improved Tether's position, occurring at a time when Debtors were tumbling towards bankruptcy and the price of Bitcoin (and the value of Tether's pre-existing collateral) was collapsing violently. Indeed, unlike so many other creditors who did not seek to dismember the Debtors during their slide into bankruptcy, as a result of these preferential transfers of Bitcoin, Tether insulated itself from the effect of Celsius's bankruptcy. Tether's efforts, of course, are now subject to intervening federal bankruptcy law. Thus, these preferential and fraudulent transfers of Bitcoin should be avoided, and the Bitcoin or its value should be recovered for the benefit of Celsius's estate. This action also seeks to recover damages caused by Tether's below-market application of such Bitcoin on that same debt, in violation of the terms of the governing agreement.

2. In 2020, Plaintiff Celsius Network Limited entered into a loan agreement (the "Token Agreement") with Tether Limited, allowing Celsius to borrow stablecoins, Tether token ("USDT") and Euro Tether ("EURT"), from Tether Limited at an interest rate between 0.333-0.55% per month.

[2] Capitalized terms not immediately defined have the meanings ascribed to them below. ECF document numbers in this Complaint refer to ECF document numbers from Case No. 22-10964-mg.

2. In 2020, Plaintiff Celsius Network Limited entered into a loan agreement (the "Token Agreement") with Tether Limited, allowing Celsius to borrow stablecoins, Tether token ("USDT") and Euro Tether ("EURT"), from Tether Limited at an interest rate between 0.333-0.55% per month. Like many of its peer cryptocurrency companies, Celsius relied in large part on stablecoins to operate certain critical aspects of its business. "Stablecoins" are digital currencies whose prices are pegged to those of other assets (such as the dollar). Stablecoins are typically backed by reserves of *non*-digital assets, like cash or marketable securities, to ensure price stability. The world's most popular stablecoin, USDT, has its price pegged to the United States dollar. USDT was created by Tether in 2014, and has been marketed and controlled by them since then.

3. To provide security for the loan, Celsius posted collateral in one of several cryptocurrencies (*e.g.*, Bitcoin, Ethereum). At the peak of its borrowing, Celsius would borrow nearly $2 billion in USDT from Tether, collateralized by tens of thousands of Bitcoin.

4. The cryptocurrency market steeply declined in the summer of 2022, and the Debtors filed the above-captioned chapter 11 cases on July 13, 2022. The Debtors' bankruptcy filing was harmful to many of its creditors. But, during the ninety-day period prior to the bankruptcy filing (the "§ 547(b) Period"), Tether took steps to insulate itself from the effect of bankruptcy. Specifically, on several occasions, Tether demanded, and received, a significant amount of new, incremental collateral to improve its position in the impending bankruptcy. That is, Plaintiffs transferred 15,658.21 Bitcoin to Defendants to satisfy these demands, each inherently on account of antecedent debt (defined below as the Preferential Top-Up Transfers).

5. In addition to the Preferential Top-Up Transfers, also during the § 547(b) Period, Plaintiffs transferred 2,228.01 Bitcoin of excess collateral to Defendants in connection with $300,000,000 of new borrowings. These transfers cross-collateralized Celsius's existing

borrowings from Tether (defined below as the "Preferential Cross-Collateralization Transfers"). These preferential transfers of Bitcoin are worth in excess of $800,000,000 in today's dollars, and are separate from and do not include over 7,000 additional Bitcoin transferred to Tether in connection with new advances of USDT and EURT to Celsius. Nor do they include 36,684,477.42 EURT and 18,556,675.01 USDT of interest and principal payments made by Celsius to Tether during the ninety-day period prior to Celsius's bankruptcy filing.

6. Tether issued its final demand to Celsius for additional collateral on June 13, 2022. Pursuant to the terms of the Token Agreement between Celsius and Tether, Celsius was entitled to ten hours to deposit additional collateral with Tether to fulfill that demand. But rather than affording Celsius the contractually permitted time to post new collateral (or, at worst, allow for a more orderly disposition of collateral), on that same day, Tether forged ahead with an improper application of 39,542.42 Bitcoin—the entirety of collateral that Celsius had posted—using the pledged Bitcoin to cover its exposure in full, but destroying Celsius's residual interest in the collateral. This final preferential transfer (as defined below, the "Preferential Application Transfer"), worth in excess of $2 billion in today's dollars, also improved Tether's position because a substantial portion of the putative collateral was avoidable, and comprised of the Preferential Top-Up Transfers, which were commingled with the entirety of the posted Bitcoin.

7. The Preferential Application Transfer also plainly breached the Token Agreement, and its effect was to purportedly dispose of Celsius's property (being held by Tether as collateral) at near the bottom of the Bitcoin market. This breach of contract caused billions of dollars in damages to Celsius as described below.

8. Tether applied Celsius's property (39,542.42 Bitcoin) to pay itself back for Celsius's outstanding loan, doing so for less than reasonably equivalent value at a time when Celsius was insolvent. As such, this application of collateral was a fraudulent transfer and should be avoided under the Bankruptcy Code and applicable state law.

9. These preferential and fraudulent transfers of Bitcoin should be avoided and recovered from Tether, and Tether should be ordered to pay damages for its unlawful application of collateral.

Celsius was insolvent. As such, this application of collateral was a fraudulent transfer and should be avoided under the Bankruptcy Code and applicable state law.

9. These preferential and fraudulent transfers of Bitcoin should be avoided and recovered from Tether, and Tether should be ordered to pay damages for its unlawful application of collateral.

THE PARTIES

10. Plaintiff Celsius Network Limited is a private limited company incorporated under the laws of England and Wales with a principal place of business in London, United Kingdom.

11. Plaintiff Celsius Network LLC is a Delaware limited liability company with a principal place of business in Hoboken, New Jersey.

12. Defendant Tether Holdings Limited is incorporated in, and is a citizen of, the British Virgin Islands. It owns Defendants Tether Limited, Tether Operations Limited, and Tether International Limited.

13. Defendant Tether Limited is incorporated in, and is a citizen of, Hong Kong.

14. Defendant Tether Operations Limited is incorporated in, and is a citizen of, the British Virgin Islands.

15. Defendant Tether International Limited is incorporated in, and is a citizen of, the British Virgin Islands.

JURISDICTION AND VENUE

16. The Court has subject matter jurisdiction pursuant to 28 U.S.C. § 1334(b) and the Standing Order of the United States District Court for the Southern District of New York referring to the Bankruptcy Judges of this District all cases and proceedings arising under the Bankruptcy Code. This court also has jurisdiction under 28 U.S.C. § 1331 because Plaintiffs' preference and fraudulent transfer claims arise under federal law, and has supplemental jurisdiction under 28 U.S.C. § 1367 over Plaintiffs' state and foreign law claims, which arise out of the same nucleus of operative facts.

17. This adversary proceeding is a "core" proceeding as defined in 28 U.S.C. § 157(b)(2). In the event that this or any other Court finds any part of this adversary proceeding to be "non-core," Code. This court also has jurisdiction under 28 U.S.C. § 1331 because Plaintiffs' preference and

fraudulent transfer claims arise under federal law, and has supplemental jurisdiction under 28 U.S.C. § 1367 over Plaintiffs' state and foreign law claims, which arise out of the same nucleus of operative facts.

18. Venue is proper in this District under 28 U.S.C. §§ 1408 and 1409 because this adversary proceeding arises under and relates to the above-captioned chapter 11 cases under the Bankruptcy Code already pending in this District. Venue is additionally proper in this District pursuant to 28 U.S.C. § 1391 because a substantial part of the events or omissions giving rise to Plaintiffs' claims occurred in this District.

19. This Court's *Findings of Fact, Conclusions of Law, and Order Confirming The Modified Joint Chapter 11 Plan of Celsius Network LLC and Its Debtor Affiliates* (the "Confirmation Order"), ECF Doc. No. 3972, in the above-captioned chapter 11 cases, approves the Debtors' chapter 11 plan, which, at Article XII (12), provides that this Court "shall retain exclusive jurisdiction to resolve any cases, controversies, suits, disputes, Causes of Action, or other matters, like this one, that may arise in connection with the Recovery Causes of Action brought by the Litigation Administrator."[3]

20. The Court has personal jurisdiction over Defendants pursuant to Rule 7004(f) of the Federal Rules of Bankruptcy Procedure because Plaintiffs' claims arise from and relate to Defendants' continuous and systematic contacts with the United States. Each Defendant transacted business in and maintained substantial contacts with the United States, including by maintaining relationships with United States entities. Each Defendant has purposefully availed itself of the privilege of doing business in the United States, and has invoked the benefits and protections of its laws. Defendants' actions were directed at, and had the intended effect of causing injury to persons located in the United States, including in this District. Indeed, Defendants have repeatedly submitted to the jurisdiction of courts in this District.

[3] In prosecuting this action, the Debtors are directed by the Blockchain Recovery Investment Consortium ("BRIC"), serving as Litigation Administrator (Complex Asset Recovery Manager). *See* ECF Doc. No. 4172.

Defendants' continuous and systematic contacts with the United States. Each Defendant transacted business in and maintained substantial contacts with the United States, including by maintaining relationships with United States entities. Each Defendant has purposefully availed itself of the privilege of doing business in the United States, and has invoked the benefits and protections of its laws. Defendants' actions were directed at, and had the intended effect of, causing injury to persons located in the United States, including in this District. Indeed, Defendants have repeatedly submitted to the jurisdiction of courts in this District.

21. The Court also has quasi in-rem jurisdiction because of Defendants' maintenance of one or more bank accounts in New York.

FACTUAL BACKGROUND

A. Plaintiffs' Business And Reliance On Loans From Tether To Operate

22. Celsius was a consumer-facing cryptocurrency company that was founded in 2017 by Alex Mashinsky, Shlomi "Daniel" Leon, and Nuke Goldstein. Celsius's primary product was a platform that allowed customers to purchase and deposit various cryptocurrencies. Like a traditional bank, Celsius paid interest to customers who deposited cryptocurrency on its platform. Celsius was known to pay some of the highest interest rates in the market to its depositors.

FACTUAL BACKGROUND

A. Plaintiffs' Business And Reliance On Loans From Tether To Operate

23. In order to generate revenue, Celsius lent its customer-deposited cryptocurrencies to third parties, who in turn would pay Celsius interest. Celsius used revenue from those loans to pay its customers interest on their deposits. Celsius also operated a Bitcoin mining operation.

24. Like many other crypto companies, Celsius borrowed "stablecoins" to fund its day-to-day operations. "Stablecoins" are digital tokens whose price is pegged to another asset (*e.g.*, the United States dollar or gold) and are typically backed by reserves of *non*-digital assets (such as cash or marketable securities) to achieve price stability.

25. Defendants control and market the world's most popular stablecoin, USDT. Each USDT token is purportedly backed by assets (such as cash and commercial paper) such that one USDT is worth one United States dollar. Defendants also control and market the EURT token, which is purportedly backed by assets such that one EURT is worth one Euro. Celsius relied on USDT and EURT to operate critical parts of its business.

B. The Token Agreement

25. Defendants control and market the world's most popular stablecoin, USDT. Each USDT token is purportedly backed by assets (such as cash and commercial paper) such that one USDT is worth one United States dollar. Defendants also control and market the EURT token, which is purportedly backed by assets such that one EURT is worth one Euro. Celsius relied on USDT and EURT to operate critical parts of its business.

B. The Token Agreement

26. On February 1, 2020, Plaintiff Celsius Network Limited and Defendant Tether Limited entered into a "Token Agreement" (the "Initial Token Agreement") allowing Celsius to borrow USDT from Tether. Celsius agreed to collateralize the borrowing by posting collateral to Tether in any of the following cryptocurrencies: (a) Ether (ETH) tokens; (2) Tether Gold (XAUt); or Bitcoin (BTC) tokens. If Celsius posted collateral to Tether in Bitcoin, the value of the Bitcoin was initially required to be 140% of the value of the amount borrowed. Celsius paid Tether interest between 0.333% and 0.55%, per month, depending on the type of collateral posted by Celsius. For example, if Celsius posted collateral in Bitcoin, it would have to pay Tether monthly interest of 0.55% on its borrowings.

27. Significantly, the Initial Token Agreement provided that no change or modification to the agreement would be valid unless made in writing and signed by the Parties—Celsius Network Limited and Tether Limited.

28. The Initial Token Agreement was amended on January 20, 2022 (as amended, the "Token Agreement" or the "Amended Token Agreement"), and is attached as Exhibit A. Like its predecessor, the Amended Token Agreement authorized Celsius to borrow USDT or EURT if Celsius posted collateral in the form of Ether, Tether Gold, or Bitcoin.

29. Like the Initial Token Agreement, the Amended Token Agreement was negotiated between Tether's representatives and Celsius personnel located in the United States. Many of the

principal terms of the Amended Token Agreement, for example, were agreed to during an all-hands call in December of 2021, just a few weeks before the amendment was signed. United States-based Celsius employees—such as Alex Mashinsky, Ron Deutsch, and Joseph Golding-Ochsner—were present at that meeting and negotiated with Tether's top executives, including Tether's CFO, Giancarlo Devasini, and its Chief Investment Officer, Silvano Di Stefano. Celsius's lead throughout the negotiations was Joseph Golding-Ochsner, a Celsius attorney based in the United States.

30. The negotiations surrounding the Amended Token Agreement centered on several key terms. Among the most important issues discussed during the negotiations was the contract's provision regarding the timeframe that Tether had to wait before it could start liquidating Celsius's collateral following a demand for additional collateral. Tether wanted to maintain the terms of the original agreement, which Tether believed allowed it to commence liquidation immediately after the value of collateral dropped below a certain threshold. Celsius proposed that it be allowed two business days to deposit additional collateral after receiving a demand for additional collateral before Tether would have any right to liquidate collateral.

31. Ultimately, the parties agreed to change the procedure by which Celsius would post additional collateral and the circumstances under which a liquidation could happen. Unlike the Initial Token Agreement, the Amended Token Agreement required Tether to send notice of a collateral demand to Celsius if the value of Celsius's posted collateral dropped below a specified threshold. After receiving such a notice, the Amended Token Agreement provided Celsius ten hours to satisfy the collateral demand. This is in contrast to the Initial Token Agreement, under which Tether was entitled, "*without further notice to the Recipient*, to sell, dispose of, and liquidate the Collateral." Now, if Celsius was unable to satisfy the collateral demand in that 10-hour window, Tether could liquidate

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, for the foregoing reasons, Plaintiffs respectfully request that this Court enter judgment in favor of the Plaintiffs and against Defendants and grant the following relief:

additional avoidable transfers that Plaintiffs learn, through discovery or otherwise, were made to Defendants during the § 547(b) Period), or, in the alternative, award Plaintiffs the present value of all Bitcoin (subject to § 550(d) and without duplication) preferentially transferred to Defendants during the § 547(b) Period;

(c) Requiring Defendants to relinquish to Plaintiffs the 39,542.42 Bitcoin (subject to § 550(d) and without duplication) fraudulently or otherwise voidably transferred by Plaintiffs to Defendants during the two-year period before filing of Celsius's bankruptcy petition (plus any additional avoidable transfers that Plaintiffs learn, through discovery or otherwise, were made to Defendants during the relevant period), or, in the alternative, award Plaintiffs the present value of all Bitcoin (subject to § 550(d) and without duplication) fraudulently or otherwise voidably transferred to Defendants;

(d) Requiring Defendants to relinquish to Plaintiffs the 15,658.21 Bitcoin, 2,228.01 Bitcoin, and 39,542.42 Bitcoin (subject to § 550(d) and without duplication) preferentially transferred by Plaintiffs to Defendants during the § 547(b) Period, or, in the alternative, award Plaintiffs the present value of all Bitcoin preferentially transferred to Defendants during the § 547(b) Period;

(e) Award Plaintiffs no less than $100,000,000.00 in damages for Defendant Tether Limited's breaches of contract and the covenant of good faith and fair dealing, plus additional damages to be determined at trial;

(f) Award Plaintiffs their attorneys' fees, pre- and post-judgment interest, and costs; and

(g) Award Plaintiffs all other relief, at law or equity, to which they may be entitled.

[8] Plaintiffs do not waive, and expressly reserve, any and all arguments with respect to the proper valuation date of the Preferential Top-Up Transfers, Preferential Cross-Collateralization Transfers, and Preferential Application Transfer and/or the form of recovery on any judgments.

(g) Award Plaintiffs all other relief at law or equity to which they may be entitled.

DATED: August 9, 2024

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By: /s/ Benjamin I. Finestone

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